

families could afford them, so they became a way for the rich to show off their wealth in public.

Funeral games gradually grew in popularity in Rome. Records tell us that in 216 BCE, 22 pairs of gladiators fought at a funeral,

Roman life. The shows became bigger, bloodier, and more spectacular than ever.

Victims and volunteers

Gladiators were a commodity to be bought and sold, just like

A GLADIATOR HAD ABOUT THREE FIGHTS A YEAR—IF THEY SURVIVED!

and at a funeral in 183 BCE, there were 60 pairs of fighters. As the games grew in size and became more exciting to watch, larger crowds turned up.

Some of the first gladiatorial contests were held in the Forum, the city's main square. With the opening of the Colosseum in 80 CE, the crowds flocked to this tailor-made killing ground. By then, gladiators were part of

cattle. The last thing anyone wanted was a shortage of gladiators. Fortunately, there was a constant supply of victims. Most of the gladiators were outcasts from society—prisoners of war, criminals, or slaves. These were people from the lowest level of society who had no choice about their fate.

Can you believe that some Roman citizens volunteered to become gladiators? They were

THE RUINS OF ROME'S FORUM, WHERE THE FIRST GLADIATORS ONCE FOUGHT. WOODEN SEATING WAS PUT UP FOR THE SPECTATORS.

